

ProjWT — WHOOP 4.0 Reverse-Engineering Build Log

Project: ProjWT (personal portfolio project — private) **Owner:** Hamza Khan **Status:** Phase 1–2 (BLE access + protocol) — in progress **Last updated:** 2026-10-01

PRIVATE / PORTFOLIO. This document and the whole ProjWT repo are a personal portfolio piece and are not to be shared publicly.

This is the **living record** of the project — every step, command, result, and decision. It is the source of truth; the PDF/Word versions are generated from this file (see **Regenerating the PDF/Word** at the end). Keep it updated as we go.

1. What we're building (and the safety line)

A personal system that talks directly to a WHOOP 4.0 band over Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE), reads its sensors, and eventually drives:

- **Biometric dashboard** — live heart rate, HRV, SpO₂, skin temp, motion.
- **Gesture control** — recognise wrist gestures from the band's accelerometer.
- **Vehicle control (Tesla Fleet API)** — *supervised only.*
- **Home / IoT automation.**

Target stack (eventual): C++ / Unreal Engine 5. **Phase-1 tooling (now):** Python — fastest way to reverse-engineer and validate the protocol before committing it to C++.

Safety constraint (non-negotiable)

Vehicle control is **active-hold, line-of-sight only**:

- You hold a gesture **while watching the car**; the car moves only while the gesture is actively held.
- Releasing the gesture (a dead-man's-switch) slows or stops the car.
- **No** "no-line-of-sight summon", **no** GPS spoofing, **no** safety-bypass.

That idea was considered and **dropped**.

2. The hardware target

- **Device:** WHOOP 4.0 band (owned by the project author).
- **Advertised name:** WHOOP_4C1656042
- **BLE address (Windows, this session):** D1:86:73:D4:62:86
- ■■ On Windows this address can be a rotating/resolvable random address, so **re-scan each session** rather than hard-coding it (see §8).

- **Battery at bring-up:** 100% (band healthy, charged via the pack; tap → LED).

3. Environment setup (Windows)

The band talks to the PC directly over BLE — **no WHOOP app, no pairing needed**. We drive it from Python.

- 1 **Install Python** (3.10+). During install tick **"Add Python to PATH."**

- 2 **Install the BLE library:**

```
python -m pip install bleak
```

- 1 **Open a terminal in the code folder.** In File Explorer, open the projwt\src folder, click the address bar, type powershell, press Enter.

- 1 **Run scripts with python first.** PowerShell will ***not*** run ble_scanner_PWT.py on its own (that just opens Notepad). Always:

```
python ble_scanner_PWT.py --name whoop
```

Common beginner errors we already hit and fixed - **"The term 'ble_scanner_PWT.py' is not recognized"** → you forgot the python prefix. Start the command with python. - **"Pressing Enter opens Notepad"** → same cause; Windows is "opening" the file instead of running it. Use python <file>. - **"ModuleNotFoundError: No module named 'bleak'"** → run python -m pip install bleak.

4. The tools we built (in src/, all _PWT)

Script	Purpose
ble_scanner_PWT.py	Discover BLE devices, print name / address / RSSI. Find the band.
gatt_explorer_PWT.py	Enumerate the band's GATT services / characteristics / descriptors.
ble_logger_PWT.py	Subscribe to notify channels and log raw packets to logs/ (JSONL). --label, --seconds.
whoop_protocol_PWT.py	The verified protocol core — framing, CRCs, command IDs, UUIDs.
ble_command_PWT.py	Send one framed command and listen for the reply.
ble_stream_PWT.py	HELLO → START → watch data channel for a continuous stream.
ble_sweep_PWT.py	Sweep a range of command IDs to find which one wakes the data channel.

Script	Purpose
<code>ble_pair_PWT.py</code>	Pair/bond with the band so it will accept our commands (encrypted link).

Everything is committed to the private repo Hamza-Khan-algonquin/projw, branch `claude/peaceful-dirac-ko6o1i`.

5. What we did, step by step (chronological)

- 1 **Charged and woke the band.** Tapping it showed the LED; battery reached 100%. Windows Bluetooth couldn't see it at first (it wasn't advertising / the WHOOP app's own pairing kept crashing). We bypassed all of that and scanned directly from Python.
- 1 **Scanned with `ble_scanner_PWT.py`.** Found WHOOP 4C1656042 at D1:86:73:D4:62:86, RSSI ≈ -61 dBm (strong, close).
- 1 **Mapped the GATT table with `gatt_explorer_PWT.py`.** Got the custom WHOOP service and its characteristics (see §6).
- 1 **Logged raw notifications with `ble_logger_PWT.py`.** Got **0 packets** at rest — **expected**: the band stays silent until told to stream. Also fixed the ugly Ctrl+C traceback and added `--seconds` auto-stop.
- 1 **Reverse-engineered the packet framing.** Community write-ups disagreed with each other (they were paraphrased summaries), so we **brute-forced the CRC parameters against a real captured packet inside a sandbox** until the framing reproduced byte-for-byte. This is now the verified core (§6).
- 1 **Sent our first real command with `ble_command_PWT.py`.** The band ***replied* with a valid, CRC-correct packet — **proof our framing is accepted by real hardware (two-way comms confirmed)**. The reply came on the *event*** channel (61080003), 32 bytes, a protobuf-style status/report — **not** a continuous sensor stream.
- 1 **Diagnosed why there was no stream.** Reference implementations perform a **HELLO handshake (cmd 0x05) first**, then START; the continuous data arrives as ~96-byte packets on the **data** channel (61080004). We had skipped the hello. Built `ble_stream_PWT.py` to do the full sequence.
- 1 **Ran the full HELLO → START sequence (`ble_stream_PWT.py`).** The band came alive — **15 packets in 30s** — but **all on the EVENT channel (61080003)**, a repeating ~2s **status beacon**, **not** the 96-byte sensor stream on the DATA channel (61080004, which stayed silent). Two outcomes:
 - **Decoded the beacon's identity fields** (see §6.5): codename `boylston`, firmware **17.2.2.0**, hardware `harvard_r10`.
 - **Found & fixed a display bug:** the tools labelled channels by the **last** 8

UUID chars, but every WHOOP characteristic ends in ...b0f8dcc6, so all channels printed the same label. They differ in the **first** block (6108000x); labelling now uses a clear name map (EVENT(03), DATA(04)...).

1 **Concluded cmd 0x03 is not the real "start streaming" opcode** (the command

IDs were always community guesses). Built `ble_sweep_PWT.py` to brute-force the correct opcode — the same empirical approach that cracked the CRC framing.

1 **Swept command IDs (`ble_sweep_PWT.py`) — and learned two big things:**

● **The band ignores unauthenticated commands.** Write-**with**-response returned

GATT Protocol Error: Insufficient Authentication (ATT error 0x05 — the command characteristic needs an **encrypted / paired link**). Write-**without**-response (our default) doesn't error, but the band **silently ignores it**. So **none** of our commands had ever actually reached the band* — every "reply" so far was the subscribe-triggered status beacon or physical motion.

● **DATA(04) is currently a motion/tap event feed.** The DATA-channel packets

lined up with **tapping / shaking / putting the charger on**, not with any command. They use our verified 0xAA framing, **type 0x30**, with an incrementing sequence and a monotonic **timestamp** — i.e. timestamped accelerometer/activity events (useful later for gesture detection).

1 **Built `ble_pair_PWT.py` and added `--pair` to the sweep/stream tools.**

Pairing establishes the encrypted link so the band will honour commands.

1 **PAIRED — and the band now answers our commands.** After pairing, a sweep

with write-with-response showed **no more** Insufficient Authentication, and commands 0x01–0x04 **each returned a genuine 32-byte type-0x30 reply** on DATA(04) (confirmed: band untouched, timestamps incrementing 0x01e28a92 → ...95 → ...98 → ...9c). cmd 0x0b was a physical tap. **Two-way authenticated command/response is working.**

1 **Found the real cause — we were watching the WRONG channel.** Comparing the

reference (christianmeurer/whoop-reader) char constants against our own scan showed an **off-by-one**: the reference assumes the write char is ...0001, but on our band ...0001 is the **service** and the write char is ...0002, so every characteristic is shifted +1. Aligning by role (write + 4 notify, in handle order) means **the real-time sensor stream is on 61080005** — the channel we had dismissed as "diagnostics". What we called "DATA(04)" is actually the **event** channel (hence one-off command acks + taps). See §6.1 for the corrected map. Also: the reference's start sequence is identical to ours (subscribe → HELLO 0x05 → START 0x03, no payload, response=True), so the opcode was never wrong — the **channel** was. And every test so far was **off-wrist** (WHOOP gates the PPG/HR stream on skin contact).

1 ← **You are here.** Next: fixed the channel map (DATA = 61080005); ***wear the band*** and stream, watching DATA(05) for 96-byte packets.

6. The verified protocol (the important part)

6.1 GATT map (from our own scan — authoritative, roles corrected)

Our band has the **service** at ...0001, so the characteristics are shifted +1 versus community write-ups that assume the **write** char is ...0001. Mapping by role (write + 4 notify, in handle order):

UUID (first block)	Role	Notes
61080001	Service	custom GATT service (not a characteristic)
61080002	Command (write)	where we send framed commands
61080003	Response / status	command responses + the ~2s status beacon
61080004	Events	async events — command acks, tap/motion (type 0x30)
61080005	DATA — real-time stream	the 96-byte sensor packets live here
61080007	Diagnostics	
00002a37	Standard Heart Rate	standard BLE HRM characteristic

We originally mis-labelled 61080004 as "data" and 61080005 as "diagnostics" (by matching the reference's numbers instead of its roles). The +1 shift means **the real sensor stream is on 61080005**. Corrected in `whoop_protocol_PWT.py`.

6.2 Packet framing — empirically verified

```
0xAA | length(2, little-endian) | CRC8(length) | PAYLOAD | CRC32(PAYLOAD, LE)
```

```
length = len(PAYLOAD) + 4          (payload plus the trailing CRC32)
CRC8    = poly 0x07, init 0x00, no reflection, over the 2 length bytes
CRC32   = standard zlib.crc32 over PAYLOAD, stored little-endian
PAYLOAD = [type][seq][cmd][data...]
type    = 0x23 for commands
```

Proof: `build_packet()` reproduces the known-good reference packet exactly:

```
aa100057230423aa8ed469a96d0000005130fef3  ← reference
aa100057230423aa8ed469a96d0000005130fef3  ← our build_packet()  ✓ MATCH
```

Run the self-test any time: `python whoop_protocol_PWT.py`.

■■ The MIT reference repo uses a **different, simpler** framing (no CRC8). We do **not** use it — **our** framing is the one the real band actually replied to.

6.3 Command IDs (community-sourced; being verified live)

Cmd	Meaning
0x01	Get battery
0x02	Get device info (fw / serial / hw)
0x03	Start real-time streaming
0x04	Stop real-time streaming

Cmd	Meaning
0x05	HELLO / handshake — send first

6.4 Real-time data packet (~96 bytes, on 61080004) — **tentative layout**

Adapted from the reference parser; **byte offsets past temperature are guesses** and will be validated against our own captures before we trust them.

Bytes	Field (tentative)
[0]	sequence
[1:3]	heart rate × 100 (uint16 LE) → BPM
[3:5]	RR interval, ms (uint16 LE)
[5]	SpO ₂ ■
[6]	skin temperature °C (offset +25)
[7:9] [9:11] [11:13]	accelerometer X / Y / Z (int16)
[13]	motion flag
[14:16]	PPG amplitude
[16:18]	ambient light
[18:20]	PPG quality
[20:91]	unknown / reserved
[92:96]	CRC32 (LE)

Captured **event** packet (32 bytes on 61080003, protobuf body) for reference:

```
aa 1c 00 ab 30 06 1d 00 2d 48 e1 01 20 1a 0c 00 32 01 00 00 02 00 42 02 0b 00 01 00 8c 60 8f ce
```

6.5 Status beacon (EVENT channel 61080003) — *decoded identity*

When we subscribe, the band emits a ~97-byte **status beacon every ~2 seconds** on the EVENT channel. It is a protobuf body (starts 08 02 a6 02 ...) carrying the device identity plus a changing counter near the tail. Decoded ASCII fields:

Field	Value
Codename	boylston
Firmware / version	17.2.2.0
Hardware revision	harvard_r10

This is a **heartbeat/status** feed, not the per-sample sensor stream. The per-sample sensor data (PPG / accel / HR) is expected as ~96-byte packets on the **DATA channel** 61080004, which is still silent — see §9 next steps.

6.6 Authentication requirement (the key blocker)

The command characteristic (61080002) requires an **encrypted/paired BLE link**. Evidence: write-with-response returns GATT Protocol Error: Insufficient Authentication (ATT error 0x05). Write-without-response doesn't raise, but the band silently discards the write. **Therefore commands only take effect after we pair/bond** (ble_pair_PWT.py, or --pair). Until then the band only emits the status beacon and motion events, regardless of what we send.

6.7 DATA(04) event packets (motion-triggered) — framing confirmed

The DATA-channel packets observed so far are our 0xAA frame with **type** 0x30:

```
aa | len(2 LE) | crc8(len) | 30 | seq | .. | timestamp(uint32 LE) | .. | crc32
```

Example: aa 10 00 57 30 24 0e 00 c8 87 e2 01 80 44 00 00 ... → len=16, crc8 OK, type=0x30, seq=0x24, timestamp=0x01e287c8 (monotonic). These fire on tap/shake/charger — accelerometer/activity events, not the continuous PPG stream we still need to unlock (via pairing + the right opcode).

7. Legal / attribution — do the referenced authors need to know?

Short answer: no obligation to notify anyone, and you don't have to publish that you used their work.

- The reference we consulted, christianmeurer/whoop-reader, is **MIT-licensed**.

The MIT license lets you use, copy, modify, and even redistribute the code — including in a closed/private project — **with one condition**: *if you redistribute their source or substantial portions of it, you must keep their copyright notice + the MIT license text with it.*

- **You are not "redistributing" it.** We only **read** it for reference and wrote

our **own** implementation (in fact with *different, independently verified* framing). So the MIT condition isn't even triggered.

- **The author is never automatically notified.** GitHub doesn't tell someone when

you read, clone, or reference their repo. There's no tracking, no callback.

- **Do you *have* to "let it be known"?** No. But ****crediting them is good**

practice** and costs nothing — so we've added a short credit note in whoop_protocol_PWT.py and here. It also makes the portfolio piece look more professional (shows you research prior art and respect licenses).

- The other names in the space (jogolden/whoomp,

bwanShiTong/reverse-engineering-whoop) — same logic. jogolden/whoomp couldn't be added to this session (not found/accessible), so we used the MIT whoop-reader instead.

Bottom line: keep the credit note (already added), don't paste their source verbatim into your repo, and you're completely fine — legally and ethically.

8. Reconnecting after a break (start-of-session checklist)

The band is stateless from our side — nothing persists on the PC. Next time you sit down:

- 1 **Charge the band** if it's been idle a while; tap it to confirm the LED.
- 2 **Open PowerShell in the code folder** — File Explorer → projwt\src folder
→ type powershell in the address bar → Enter.

- 1 **Re-scan for the band** (the address may have changed):

```
python ble_scanner_PWT.py --name whoop
```

Copy the address it prints (e.g. D1:86:73:D4:62:86).

- 1 **(Optional) confirm the GATT map is unchanged:**

```
python gatt_explorer_PWT.py <ADDRESS>
```

- 1 **Pair once** (only needed the first time, or after --unpair; the bond persists across sessions):

```
python ble_pair_PWT.py <ADDRESS>
```

- 1 **Find the stream opcode** (current task — see §9), band held still:

```
python ble_sweep_PWT.py <ADDRESS> --pair --with-response
```

Once we know the right opcode, stream with:

```
python ble_stream_PWT.py <ADDRESS> --pair --with-response --seconds 30
```

- 1 **Send Claude the newest file in logs** so we can decode/continue.

If bleak is missing again (new machine): `python -m pip install bleak`. If nothing is found in the scan: make sure the band is charged and near the PC, and that no other app (the WHOOP phone app) is holding the connection.

9. Current status & next steps

Done

- Physical bring-up, BLE discovery, full GATT map.
- Packet framing reverse-engineered **and verified both ways** (we sent a command and the real band returned a valid CRC-checked reply).
- Confirmed two-way comms live; decoded the device-identity status beacon (firmware 17.2.2.0, hardware harvard_r10).
- Tooling for scan / explore / log / command / stream / sweep.

Done (new)

- **Pairing works** (Windows ConfirmOnly ceremony); the authenticated link lets the band accept commands. Commands 0x01–0x04 return type-0x30 replies.

Next

- 1 **Wear the band (snug, tight skin contact)** and stream — now watching the corrected channel DATA(05) = 61080005:

```
python ble_stream_PWT.py <ADDRESS> --with-response --seconds 30
```

(Pairing persists, so --pair is optional now.) If DATA(05) floods with ~96-byte packets while you hold still, that's the live sensor stream — send Claude the log.

- 1 If still quiet, try a start payload and/or longer listen:

```
python ble_stream_PWT.py <ADDRESS> --with-response --start-data 01 --seconds 20
```

- 1 Build decode_realtime_PWT.py from the captured bytes — validate HR against your actual resting heart rate, then lock in the accel / temp / SpO₂ offsets.
- 1 Gesture recognition from the accelerometer stream.
- 2 Port the verified protocol to C++ for the UE5 phase.

10. Regenerating the PDF / Word versions

This Markdown file is the master. The PDF and Word copies are generated from it with a small pure-Python script (no LibreOffice needed, so it runs on your Windows machine too). One-time setup:

```
python -m pip install reportlab python-docx
```

Then, from the repo root, regenerate BUILD_LOG_PWT.pdf and BUILD_LOG_PWT.docx any time you edit this file:

```
python Tools/export_docs_PWT.py
```

Re-run it whenever you update this log so the shareable copies stay in sync.

ProjWT build log — private portfolio project. Keep this file updated.